He offered strong praise for many of its provisions, particularly the shutdown of the heavy water reactor at Arak, a step he called “quite good”, effectively blocking Iran’s path to a plutonium bomb. In a perfect world, he added, the agreement would also have barred Iran from producing enriched uranium. “But if it were possible, it would have been reached along these very long two years of haggling,” he said. “And frankly, [among] those who oppose the agreement, I didn’t see anybody that came out with a real comprehensive solution that is different. So I think that we should be realistic.”

The security services are not monolithic, of course. Amos Yadlin, a former head of military intelligence and the Zionist Camp’s candidate for defense minister in the 2015 election, called it a “highly problematic agreement that entails risks to Israel’s national security.” Still, the evidence suggested that most of Israel’s generals saw the deal as an opportunity, not a disaster—a view not limited to the retired ones. In August 2015, for the first time, the army released its strategic program to the public. The document did not mention Iran as a nuclear threat. An army spokesman cautioned against reading too much into the text, but analysts quickly interpreted it as yet another sign of discord with Netanyahu.

A last mission

Two weeks after Lieberman took office, on a sweltering Thursday afternoon in June, the normally staid Herzliya conference was the hottest item on the political calendar. The keynote speaker was Ehud Barak. He was unpopular with the Israeli public, but he still had a following in the press corps, and he promised them a bombshell.

His warm-up act was the recently unemployed Moshe Ya’alon, whose typically dry cadence obscured a harsh attack on his former boss. He accused Netanyahu of “fear-mongering”, of trying to convince Israelis that a “second Holocaust” was looming around the corner. Bibi had spent years warning Israelis that the Palestinians, Iran, and even the BDS movement jeopardized their very existence. Ya’alon was blunt. “At this point, and for the foreseeable future, there is no existential threat facing Israel,” he said.

Barak took the stage a few hours later, and his speech didn’t disappoint. The ex-commando had already prepared the ground, telling Channel 10 in May that Israel had been “infected by the seeds of fascism”. He repeated